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THE GRAND GALLERIA DETECTIVE AGENCY, LTD.

São Paulo, 1994. College admissions, conspiracies, heavy metal, Satan. She's seventeen, and her investigation is getting a bit out of control.



CURSED FREQUENCY

PORCHESTER PUBLISHING

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THE STAMP SHOP

▶ ⌊GRAND GALLERIA, 4TH FLOOR · MON OCT 10 1994 · 1:40 PM⌋

Odete reached the corner of Ipiranga and São João a little after one in the afternoon, after cutting across downtown on foot from Tiradentes. School had let out at twelve-thirty: ETESP, the new state technical school in Luz. From school to the Galleria was thirty minutes on foot or twenty-five by bus. The bus was not worth the wait. She made the trip five times a week, in Dr. Martens combat boots.

She could have gone straight to work, but she kept walking to the Casa Califórnia. She had a Bragança sausage on a bread roll with tomato-and-onion relish and an orange-and-beet juice, served in a sunset-colored pitcher. The sandwich cost the equivalent of an hour and a half of work at her uncle's counter, but it was worth every minute.

In Santa Cecília, her grandmother's townhouse was twenty minutes on foot from the Galleria and another twenty from school. That was why she had decided to keep living with her grandmother instead of moving to Alphaville, a gated suburb outside the city, when her parents moved. A matter of geography: all three points of her day were within reach without a bus or the subway. She also lived near the Retrô, a club that goths, punks, and metalheads ended up at. When she was little, she passed it early in the morning on the way to school and saw people dressed in black coming out wrecked, coats over their arms, makeup smeared. At fifteen she went in for the first time.

She was in no hurry to finish lunch. The stamp shop had no customers in the first hour of the afternoon, rarely in the next two, and the distinction between open-with-Odete and open-without-Odete was in practice irrelevant to anyone but Uncle Osmar, who was not there to check.

She walked. A fine drizzle was falling, darkening the sidewalk and the clothes of the people going by. Nobody opened an umbrella for so little. She crossed the Viaduto do Chá, passed in front of the Theatro Municipal, and downtown kicked into gear around her. On the sidewalk, a street vendor was selling bootleg CDs next to a newsstand. The campaign flyers from the previous week's presidential election still turned up in the corners the street sweepers' brooms had missed.

At the newsstand, *Placar* was celebrating a hundred years of soccer in Brazil, *SuperGamePower* splashed the Mega Drive versus Super Nintendo war across its cover, and a *Capricho* mourned the end of New Kids on the Block. The news magazines were about the Real Plan, of course (the July 1994 reform that brought in a new currency, the real), and were still stewing over the presidential impeachment of two years before. Farther on, a man sitting on a Styrofoam cooler tossed off a weak crack about Morticia, and she did not bother to listen.

A man was handing out flyers. Odete took one to be polite and read it as she walked: DIVINE HEALING SERVICE EVERY TUESDAY, FREE ADMISSION, an address on Brigadeiro Tobias and an illustration of rays of light coming down on a kneeling silhouette. Downtown was full of churches like that, set up in stores that had closed. She folded the paper in four and tucked it into the pocket of her trench coat, so as not to throw it away in the man's face.

She reached Rua 24 de Maio, record-store row. Just as Santa Ifigênia was electronics row and Teodoro Sampaio was instrument row. Every street downtown had its trade, helped along by rents that fell after the middle class started shopping at malls. The mall had the mainstream, but downtown had the strange. The strange was what Odete wanted.

The entrance to the Galleria was twenty meters away. More than a door, the entrance was a concave mouth open to the street. In the window of an accessories shop, a handwritten card gave the price of a "gold" bracelet: 3.50 URV, the placeholder unit that had turned into the real one to one, crossed out in pen, and underneath, in different handwriting, R$ 3.50. The Real Plan was

three months old. Odete barely remembered the first in the series, the Cruzado Plan, which had brought in a currency of its own, the cruzado, when she was a kid. This July, prices had stopped going up. In August it still looked like a trap. Now in October, we'll see if inflation had really been tamed.

The building was three decades old and had been landmarked by Conpresp, the city's preservation council, two years before. It had almost five hundred shops lined up along narrow corridors. One of them was hers. She started up. The staircase was a spiral of worn marble, with a red handrail and wedge-shaped steps, wide on the outer edge and narrow at the core, where a whole foot did not fit. On busy days there was a standoff on every floor, with whoever came the other way always fighting for the roomy outer side. Climbing four floors in a black trench coat and Dr. Martens in the heat of São Paulo's spring took conviction. That day, the drizzle helped her cope. Each floor had its tribe, settled there by sedimentation: several economies in a single building, each with its own rules for when to open, when to close and how loud to play.

She passed through the lower floors without stopping: the second was in full swing, the third was louder than usual. On the stairs between the third and the second, a guy sitting on a step let enough sound leak from his Walkman for Odete to recognize "Wave of Mutilation." On the fourth, the woman who ran the silk-screening shop waved without pausing as she stretched a screen on its frame. Through the open door, the ghosts of earlier T-shirts on every horizontal surface: skulls, band logos, dragons. The building fed on itself: she and her crew made the T-shirts that the shops on the first and second floors sold.

The fourth-floor corridor ran between two voids. On one side, the facade open to the north: the rooftops of the historic center, the church on Largo do Paissandu with the bells that kept the neighborhood's time. On the other, the light well. The stamp shop was on the south side. Odete put a hand to her neck and fished out the three keys she kept on a leather cord: one purely decorative, from Benedito Calixto, which opened nothing; the one for the shop's padlock; and the one for her grandmother's townhouse. She unlocked the padlock and raised the grate, which went up with a crash. Shop open.

REPÚBLICA STAMPS, THE STAMP KING, was one of the smaller spaces on the floor: twenty-odd square meters, without the panoramic view of the shops at the ends of the floor, the kind of space the real estate listing would

describe as "economical." There was no sign with that name at the entrance. Its sign was just a big rubber stamp, with no words. A visual argument, and perchance useful in the case of foreign and/or illiterate customers. It was the only thing that announced the existence of the business, and Odete had concluded long ago that her uncle was not especially interested in being a tycoon. The full company name appeared only on the company tax registration card and on the customer receipts that were never issued.

Behind the counter, the stamps were where they always were. Ink pads lined up on the bottom shelf, drying out. In the middle of the counter, the order book lay open to the same page. New orders were rare enough that the same sheet lasted for weeks.

Her shop, like every other one in the building, had a low-ceilinged mezzanine her uncle used as a storeroom, and underneath it fit the entire business: the counter, the machines, the shelves, and a small bathroom of grimy white tile and a tiny sink whose main function was (trying) to wash ink off your hands.

Odete pushed back the black bangs that were starting to fall into her eyes. The top and the sides of her head, normally buzzed down with clippers, were already due for maintenance. It was a Chelsea cut, complete with wisps at the sides and back, a style that had its fifteen minutes in the late seventies, when she was born.

She took the three-ring binder out of her backpack. On the cover, under clear plastic, was the cover of *Rio*, the Duran Duran album. She opened it to the page she had been putting off since Monday: the reading list for the entrance exam. A short prose piece by Drummond, with the instruction in the corner: identify the lyric I and discuss its relationship with urban space.

She wrote the date at the top of the page. Muffled sounds rose from the ground floor: pedestrians cutting through to São João, the right-hand escalator, the one that worked. She wrote the first sentence. Read it. Crossed it out. Wrote another.

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► ⌊GRAND GALLERIA, 4TH FLOOR · MON OCT 10 1994 · 3:00 PM⌋

The first customer showed up a little after three. He was a man of about fifty with the look of a lifer from some government office: shiny suit, imitation-leather briefcase. He walked in knowing what he wanted.

The man asked to examine a date stamp: Colop Printer 2860. He set the digits to the current date and pressed it against the paper: 10/10/94. "Is this a good one?"

"Oh, you bet, you can trust it. That one's the VW Santana Quantum of stamps."

He approved the price, paid cash and waited for his change. While Odete opened the register, he asked if they did custom stamps. They did: ready the next day at the list price, but out today for a rush fee.

The second customer showed up around four-thirty, near the end of the workday. This kind of commotion and frantic demand was abnormal for the shop, and Odete struggled to hide her irritation. The child was about seven and looked around with the seriousness of a building inspector. Behind her, a woman in her early thirties, looking incredulous, trailed along.

The child got straight to the point. "Do you have a Hello Kitty stamp?"

Odete looked at the shelf of ready-made stamps. None of them was a known character. A set of dinosaur stamps that had come in the year before, on the *Jurassic Park* wave, was the closest thing.

"I don't, but there's this one of the Herculoids," Odete said.

The child did not back down. "What about My Melody?"

"I don't even know what that is."

The mother cut in: "It's a Japanese bunny. Do you have any bunnies?"

"There's this one." Odete showed a stamp with an almost photorealistic hare.

"But what kind of bunny is that?" the child said, accusingly.

"Super Easter Bunny."

"Easter? It's October."

"Easter of '95. The early bunny gets the egg."

They bought the bunny. Odete wrote it in the order book and went back to her binder. Around five she locked up. The building closed at seven, but five was good enough.

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Book 1: Cursed Frequency

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